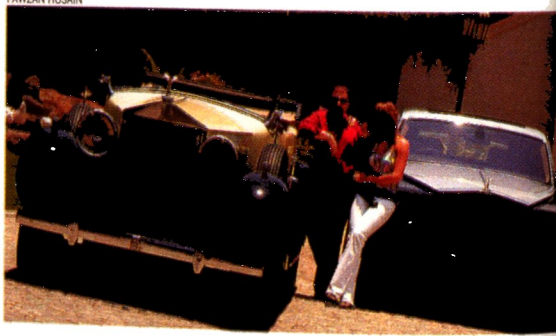


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The world wealth report

put the number of millionaires in India at 93,000, but money and indulgence also led to a dangerous gun culture

teens. The most shocking case of indulgent parents was a Chennai doctor and his wife who let their 15-year-old son conduct a Caesarean operation so he could set a world record!

Combined with this was the birth of gun culture. Cases of enmity, rejected lovers or drunken brawls being settled by the gun revealed a scary underbelly of Indian society. The Gurgaon schoolboy who took his father's pistol and, along with his friend, shot another schoolboy over a minor fracas showed what a dangerous cocktail over-indulgent parents and accessibility to lethal weapons was becoming. The good news was that there was another, brighter side to the affluence coin. A series of surveys revealed some heartening results. ■ Indian youth were the happiest in the world according to Swedish researchers. India's score of 127 makes it a nation of "happy people". The global average is 92.

■ Indians are most optimistic about their economy (77 per cent) than their counterparts across the world (average 36 per cent), found a McKinsey global survey of business executives.

The feel-good factor was reflected every-

where: marriages got more creative, Indians holidaying abroad reached a record 8.3 million and the rash of stand-alone restaurants set new standards of ambience, range and quality of cuisine and design. The sartorial mood matched the theme which was celebration of the new India. That was best reflected in Mumbai's iconic fashion store Ensemble's twentieth anniversary show where designers presented India-inspired outfits in rich brocades, crushed silk embellished with jewels and hints of gold and copper radiating a quiet opulence, much like the urban scene in 2007. Projections for 2008 suggest that it will be an extension of the year gone by, a continuation of the India story which has captured mind and media space across the world. There's already one indication of that. Iconic luxury brand Hermes' has announced India as its inspiration for 2008. It's no coincidence that next year will see the marquee opening its first stand-alone stores in India, along with Christof and Cartier. And, with reduced taxes on imported liquor and wines, a larger community can raise a toast to 2008—with Moët & Chandon's vintage champagne. ■